Ideation Document: Coordinated Pause Escrow System

What it does

A mechanism that lets competing AI companies "vote" cryptographically and anonymously on a shared concern about a dangerous model, and trigger a coordinated pause only if enough companies (an M-of-N threshold) have voted — without any company knowing who else voted until the threshold is reached. It answers directly Vance's call for companies to "pause unilaterally" (paragraph 9) — but without the legal exposure that such a unilateral call creates.

Motivation

The article states explicitly (paragraph 9) that voluntary coordination between competitors on an "emergency stop" requires an antitrust exemption — without one, even good intentions expose the coordinators to lawsuits. The idea: build this privacy and anonymity into the protocol itself, so that no company "gives away" its identity as the one who initiated the concern before the threshold is approved.

Target audience

A consortium of leading AI labs (Anthropic, OpenAI, Google, etc.) that want an emergency coordination mechanism without competitive or legal risk.

Similar solutions

Pedersen Commitments and Hash Time-Locked Contracts (HTLC) are well known in the crypto world (Bitcoin, the Lightning Network) for commit-reveal scenarios, but have not previously been applied to regulatory-industrial coordination; FROST (threshold Schnorr signatures) is common in managing shared wallets, not in AI safety decisions.

Expected challenges

Defining an "approved purpose" for a pause without enabling abuse (a politically or competitively motivated pause); handling a company that joins too late (after the threshold was already reached); preserving anonymity before the threshold against the need for full identification afterwards, for enforcement and accountability.